

Personal effects
Infantrymen had to carry everything they needed for life in the field on their backs. A basic wash kit weighed little, but heavier items were often jettisoned on long marches.

generally adequate, soldiers often indulged in foraging and pillage. Since the war was mostly fought on Confederate territory, this was tolerated or even encouraged by commanders, most notoriously during the March to the Sea across Georgia in 1864.

Life in army camp was a variant on age-old military traditions. Soldiers followed a routine of drill and fatigues regulated by bugle calls or the beating of the drum. Punishments for indiscipline could be crude and severe, ranging from hanging by the thumbs to the excruciating "bucking" – tying the arms and legs together around a rifle.

Disease was ever-present and more soldiers died of diarrhoea and dysentery than lost their lives in combat. As the war went on, improved medical services and tighter discipline – leading to better cleanliness – cut the death rate. Whenever warfare became static, though, as in the sieges of Vicksburg or Richmond, epidemics flared up. The worst lot was to be taken prisoner; thousands died in the awful conditions at Andersonville, Georgia, and in other Confederate camps.

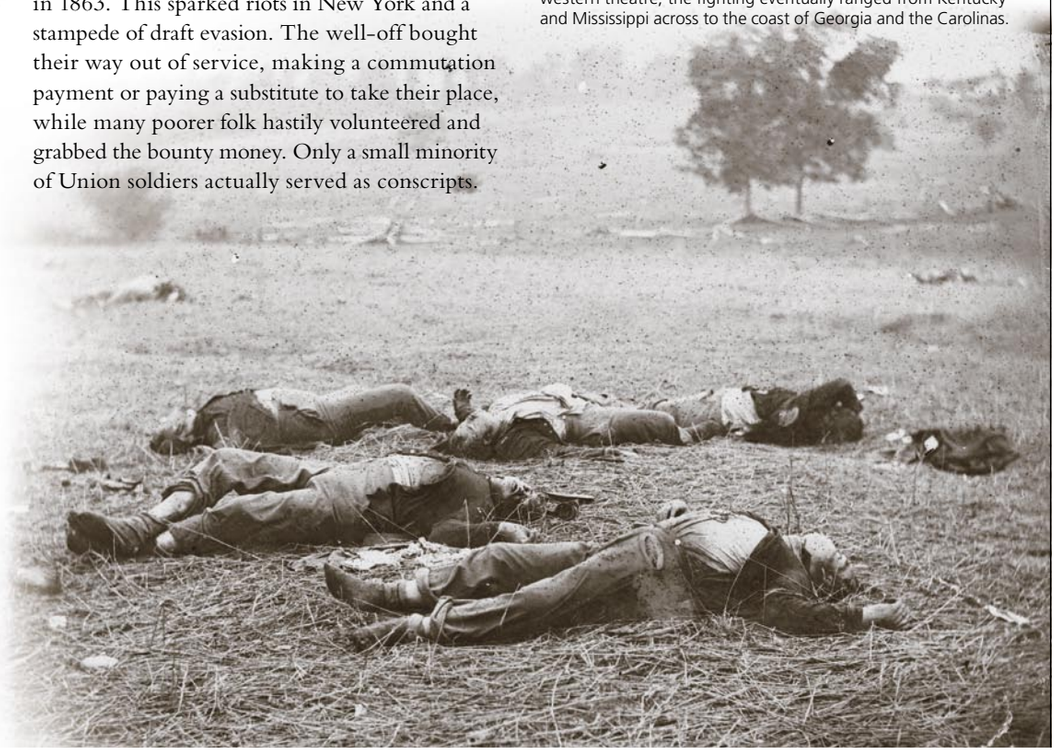
CHANGING ARMY

Combat may have caused numerically smaller losses than disease, but the level of casualties in pitched battles mounted alarmingly as the war grew in intensity. At Antietam in September 1862 the Union forces suffered 12,000 casualties in a single day's fighting. In the decisive battle of Gettysburg the following year there were around 23,000 Union casualties, and their Confederate opponents suffered even heavier losses.

Mounting casualties and the prolongation of the war increased the Union army's manpower requirements while simultaneously blunting popular enthusiasm to volunteer. When the offer of bounty money failed to attract enough recruits, the Federal government introduced conscription in 1863. This sparked riots in New York and a stampede of draft evasion. The well-off bought their way out of service, making a commutation payment or paying a substitute to take their place, while many poorer folk hastily volunteered and grabbed the bounty money. Only a small minority of Union soldiers actually served as conscripts.



Progress of the war
The war developed into a struggle on two fronts. In the eastern theatre the Union's Army of the Potomac fought in a relatively restricted area of Virginia, Maryland, and Pennsylvania. In the western theatre, the fighting eventually ranged from Kentucky and Mississippi across to the coast of Georgia and the Carolinas.



Gettysburg
Union casulties lie on the field of battle near Herbst woods in Gettysburg, Pennsylvania. The battle of Gettysburg was one of the largest and bloodiest of the war. After three days of fighting, around 50,000 Union and Confederate soldiers lay dead.